

If the creditor happens to be obstinate and an optimist, he gets mass-production excuses and some autobiography. The chapters may be three or ten, but the last one is always: "Well, I didn't know enough to be satisfied with a good profit. I didn't think there was any top to them. I was a fool."

Times when a postscript is deemed necessary, it is always: "It serves me right."

Millions of these stock-market losers seem incapable of forgetting their Waterloo. The blunders of '29 hide the vista of possible successes in '32. It is a bad state of mind for a nation to fall into, especially when it is demonstrable that what the multitude, in their ignorance, did in 1929, the élite, in their wisdom, did in 1930 and 1931. The minus microbe plays no favorites. Neither native ability nor business experience, neither unusual sagacity nor ample capital can keep men from losing money at losing time.

Some thousands of years ago a wise man said: "There is a time to get and a time to lose." And don't forget that Solomon, in his day, was considered quite a getter.

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The average man is apt to endow the multi-millionaire with infallible judgment in business matters. That probably is the reason why we hear so much about the present non-spending of the presumably rich. Perfectly decent families are insulted, vocally and in print, for not buying more of everything. What is a tragedy if you are idle, prudence if you are on part time and thrift if you are underpaid, becomes murder in the first degree in the rich man who could instantly end the depression by buying four overcoats or ten hats and considerably wearing them out in a week.